

HOUSE JOINT RESOLUTION 475

By Clemmons

A RESOLUTION to honor the memory of Colonel James Russell Dismukes of Nashville.

WHEREAS, the members of this General Assembly were greatly saddened to learn of the passing of Colonel James Russell Dismukes; and

WHEREAS, Colonel Dismukes was an exemplary public servant and consummate professional who worked assiduously to improve the quality of life for his fellow citizens in numerous capacities; and

WHEREAS, born on September 20, 1932, in Birmingham, Alabama, Colonel James Russell Dismukes was the son of Colonel Roy Lloyd Dismukes and Mary Aileen Russell Dismukes; and

WHEREAS, Colonel Jim Dismukes was raised in a family that instilled in him a deep sense of duty and discipline; his father was an Army colonel, and his mother was an organist in the church; and

WHEREAS, he attended C.K. McClatchy High School in Sacramento, California, and graduated from the University of Alabama in 1955 and was commissioned as a second lieutenant in the U.S. Army, embarking on a military career that would span nearly two decades; and

WHEREAS, Colonel Dismukes distinguished himself as a leader and strategist during his military service, when he was assigned to fill key positions both stateside and abroad; he served in an advisory position in Vietnam and played a critical role in training and assisting Allied Forces of over 18,000 troops under General Creighton William Abrams, Jr., who commanded military operations in Vietnam from 1968 to 1972; and

WHEREAS, Colonel Dismukes later commanded units within the 101st Airborne Division and received a number of military honors and commendations for his service, including the Bronze Star for Valor, the Legion of Merit, and the Combat Infantry Badge; and

WHEREAS, in the years leading up to his retirement in Jacksonville, Florida, he was given the honor of top Army recruiter in the United States by United States Senator Lawton Chiles; and

WHEREAS, Colonel Dismukes met the love of his life, Karen, on the tennis courts at Middle Tennessee State University; the couple married in 1968 at the United Methodist Church in Murfreesboro; and

WHEREAS, working side by side in their retail business, Jim and Karen Dismukes also acquired real estate and restored three homes on the National Register of Historic Homes; they later relocated to Nashville but remained members of the Monteagle Sunday School Assembly; and

WHEREAS, after opening The Village Square and The French Shoppe 2 in Murfreesboro, which later expanded to Nashville, the couple transformed retail by taking fashion on the road, bringing their curated collections directly to customers in private showings; and

WHEREAS, an active part of his community, Colonel Dismukes shared his time and talents in support of a number of charitable efforts, including Vanderbilt Children's Hospital and the Dupont Country Club's Autism Foundation; and

WHEREAS, Colonel Dismukes was also deeply devoted to his family, and he always endeavored to remain true to family values of the highest order; and

WHEREAS, a loving husband, devoted father, and doting grandfather, he is survived by his wife, Karen Elrod Dismukes; daughters, Tara Dismukes (Ben) Wegdam and Karen Aileen Dismukes (William) Cooper; son, James Russell (Christy) Dismukes II; grandchildren, Kiki

Wegdam, Paris Wegdam, Ben Wegdam, Jr., Willis Cooper, Constance Cooper, James Russell Dismukes III, and Lana Dismukes; and

WHEREAS, he will be sadly mourned but fondly remembered by his brothers and sisters-in-law, Cecil (Tommye) Elrod III, Susan (George) Creagh, Beth (Roscoe) Scofield, and David Elrod (Nancy Burns); cousin, Margaret (Jed) Hendrick; and a host of extended family, dear friends, and admirers; and

WHEREAS, in addition to his parents, he was preceded in death by his father- and mother-in-law, Cecil Elrod, Jr., and Betty Elrod; and his uncle, Homer (Linda) Russell; and

WHEREAS, Colonel Dismukes leaves behind an indelible legacy of integrity and probity in public life, compassion and loyalty in private life, and diligence and dedication in all his chosen endeavors; and

WHEREAS, it is fitting that the members of this General Assembly should pause to remember the bountiful life of this exceptional public servant and human being; now, therefore,

BE IT RESOLVED BY THE HOUSE OF REPRESENTATIVES OF THE ONE HUNDRED FOURTEENTH GENERAL ASSEMBLY OF THE STATE OF TENNESSEE, THE SENATE CONCURRING, that we honor the memory of Colonel James Russell Dismukes, reflecting fondly upon his impeccable character and his stalwart commitment to living the examined life with courage and conviction.

BE IT FURTHER RESOLVED, that an appropriate copy of this resolution be prepared for presentation with this final clause omitted from such copy and upon proper request made to the appropriate clerk, the language appearing immediately following the State seal appear without House or Senate designation.